The Guardian

one stop english

‘It’s a bit too castle-y’: plans to turn Cumbrian fortress into eco-attraction

Level 2: Intermediate

1 Warmer

a. Which place would you most like to visit on holiday? Why? What would you like to do there?

- Thailand
- Costa Rica
- Tanzania
- Australia
- Brazil

2 Key words

a. Fill the gaps in the sentences using these key words from the text.

ancestors	attractive	challenges	eco-friendly	energy	prediction
remote	ruin	solar	tourism	underground	valuable

1. Something that comes from the sun is _____.
2. _____ is a source of power used to make things work.
3. Something that is designed not to hurt the environment is _____.
4. When something is _____, it is pleasant, and it interests you.
5. A place that is very far away from other places and may be difficult to get to is _____.
6. Difficult things or situations that need determination to solve or fix are _____.
7. Something that is worth a lot of money is _____.
8. _____ is a business that helps people plan and book holidays.
9. A _____ is when you say what you think will happen in the future.
10. When you destroy or damage something, you _____ it.
11. Something that is under the surface of the earth is _____.
12. All the people who are related to you who lived a long time ago are your _____.

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b. Use some of the key words in part A to complete the sentences.

1. The hiking trail was very quiet because it was in a really _____ place.
2. I try to buy _____ products from companies who care about the environment.
3. With determination, you can overcome _____ in life.
4. People always make _____ about what’s going to happen, but no one really knows for sure.

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Helen Pidd

26 February 2023

1 In 1990, the year Ewan Frost-Pennington was born, the final bears left Muncaster Castle in northwest England. Winnie, a black bear, went to Dudley Zoo, along with Inca, her daughter, and her sister, Gretel.

2 Thirty years later, the bear area is now a solar farm. It was Frost-Pennington’s idea. He is responsible for the 800-year-old castle, and he is trying to make Muncaster the first carbon-zero castle in the UK.

3 In early 2022, the 32-year-old was living in San Francisco and working in the energy industry. Now he is earning 25 per cent of what he made before and is living in a 14th-century building with his grandparents’ old furniture.

4 His new job at Muncaster is to figure out a way to make the 800-hectare (2,000-acre) place not just eco-friendly but also attractive to tourists.

5 Its remote location, an hour off the M6 motorway and two hours from Manchester Airport, can make it difficult to attract foreign tourists. So Frost-Pennington must be creative. In April, he will host Muncaster’s first drag show and its Sausage Fest. This summer, there will be a music festival and a 10km race along – and in – the River Esk.

6 Living in a remote castle with his parents has its challenges for a young, single man (his US girlfriend who came with him from California did not stay). “To be honest, I’m finding it a bit too castle-y,” he said. “It’s like I’m wearing the clothes of my ancestors.”

7 The castle is listed as a historical site. Because it is protected, he cannot put up his own pictures and it is very cold most of the time. 60 per cent of their energy use comes from either solar power or underground heat, which are carbon-zero.

8 From his bedroom window, Frost-Pennington can see the hills of Eskdale, with Scafell Pike, England’s highest mountain, in the distance. Frost-Pennington is keen to point out the 0.8-mile (1.3km) hole he made for the castle’s heating system.

9 Built to keep out the Scots, Muncaster Castle has been in the family for at least 800 years. Frost-Pennington’s mother, Iona, took over aged 23. Her parents and grandparents sold the family silver and most of the original 12,000-hectare estate to keep the castle.

10 Sometimes the tourism business makes less than £10,000 a year. Iona Frost-Pennington pays herself just £3,000 a year.

11 Growing up in a castle with 31 hectares of gardens and a special area for owls could be fun. It was amazing to run and play games outside with his brother, Fraser, and sister, Isla, though “you’d never find anyone” without deciding exactly where to play, says Frost-Pennington.

12 Ewan learned at a young age not to tell other children where he lived – “otherwise you become Castle Boy. There is no way of saying ‘I live in a castle’ without sounding like an idiot,” he said. Still, he wants to show that he can attract more visitors.

13 Though one day the castle will be his, Iona hasn’t yet allowed her son to touch the family’s most valuable object. In the 1460s, one of their ancestors allowed Henry VI to hide in the castle during the War of the Roses. Henry left a Venetian glass bowl as a thank-you gift along with a prediction that as long as the bowl is there, the Penningtons will stay at Muncaster.

14 Waving the *Guardian* goodbye, Frost-Pennington says he is looking forward to the article: “I just hope it doesn’t turn out to be a story of the son who ruined everything.”

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3 Comprehension check

a. Answer the questions using information from the article.

1. Where is Muncaster Castle?
2. Who are Winnie, Inca, and Gretel?
3. What is the bear area now?
4. How old is the castle?
5. What is Frost-Pennington trying to do at Muncaster Castle?
6. Where did he live before Muncaster?
7. Who does Frost-Pennington live with at the castle?
8. What can he see from his bedroom window?
9. How much does Muncaster’s tourism business make in a year?
10. What is the family’s most valuable possession?

4 Key language

a. Match each phrasal verb to its meaning.

1. point out	a. have a certain result at the end
2. figure out	b. build or hang something, such as a fence or pictures
3. keep out	c. feel happy or excited about something in the future
4. turn out	d. be able to understand something or solve a problem
5. put up	e. change from being a child to an adult
6. take over	f. stop someone or something from entering a place
7. grow up	g. show someone who a person is or where something is
8. look forward to	h. begin to do something that someone else was doing

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5 Discussion

a. Discuss these statements.

- “Everyone should only travel in an eco-friendly way to protect the environment.”
- “All buildings should use solar energy sources.”

6 In your own words

a. Search online to find more information about eco-friendly travel. Find some top locations for eco-friendly holidays and what you can do in those places. You could use one of the locations from the Warmer exercise if you wish.

b. Report your findings to the class.

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